Figure B.1 Microservices topic worldwide since 2004 (Source: Google Trends)

I tend to think that a microservice is just a good, well-designed service. We increasingly say *microservice* when referring to what used to be called a *service*. That could be why the term is on the rise again; but whatever the reason, the question remains: What do we mean when we say *microservice*?

You could look for the answer in a wiki or a blog, but even writing a definition has been tried so many times that each new attempt destroys the credibility of the answer, if not the question itself. So let's try this: let's forget about microservices for a while and look for the characteristics that are important in developing distributed systems. You probably won't be surprised that some of these characteristics are often included in the definition of microservices.

To find these ideas, let's start from the beginning and consider the characteristics of past distributed systems that we still consider important in the development of systems today. I am not a historian, but I believe the exercise will be fruitful.

B.1.1 Let's bound a context

The term *middleware* was first used in a 1968 NATO Science Committee report (Peter Naur and Brian Randell, eds.) to describe "the software we put in the middle to serve as cogs in a system." Figure B.2 shows the diagram from that report.